SEP would transfer a lump sum towards an account I operated, towards salaries of the 75MYG scientists. The Government of India paid for the 25MYG men. Initially, all were paid the same salary of 2,500 Francs, but in the second year, SEP effected a pay hike that ironically added to my problems. Now there was a 5-Franc difference between the salaries of the two groups, and this was a disparity that could create some bad blood. I decided to hold back the difference amount till the Government of India too matched the salary. This was only a matter of a few months, but it had the potential to trigger the rebellion my wife had forewarned.

Now, the specially-created salary account of the team had some restrictions. I can draw money from the bank to disburse the salaries, but I cannot deposit. The only two accounts from which the bank accepted deposits were those of the Government of India and SEP. So I withdrew the difference amount of 5 Francs every month that added up to 2000 Francs after a while. I kept the money in the office apartment, with Unni as the custodian.

Then came a nuisance in the form of an auditor from the London office of the ministry of external affairs. The auditor called up to say he would be in Vernon the week next. I said he was welcome. Later, I realised that he had expected me to pick him up from the Vernon railway station and bring him to our office. I had some important work to do at the office, and didn't care for bureaucratic subservience, which anyway an auditor didn't deserve from a team head of ISRO.

When the auditor landed at our doorstep, I gave him a quick introduction of the team and left him with Unni, our office assistant who was up-to-date with the accounts. 'You may talk to me after Unni explains everything,' I told him and took his leave. Unni later told me that he was bitter throughout the stock-taking. First, he questioned Unni about the purchase of the photocopier machine. Why in the name of the Indian Embassy, and as a purchase of the department of space. Unni noted down such 'big' questions, which he promised that I would later answer. The auditor was apparently finding nothing he could question, when he chanced upon the 2,000 Francs kept in the office safe. He went bonkers.